

AI-powered Deaf Assistance Device

Pranav Arya R S

Artificial Intelligence and machine learning
St joseph's college of engineering
pranavarya2005@gmail.com

Sreevatsan V P

Artificial intelligence and machine learning
St joseph's college of engineering
sreesreevatsan55@gmail.com

Deepa

Artificial Intelligence and machine learning
St joseph's college of engineering
deepa@stjosephs.in

Abstract—Hearing difficulties hamper the ability to distinguish essential environmental sounds, thus posing a threat to those suffering from deafness or hard of hearing. In this paper, we present a groundbreaking Deaf Assistance Device based on AI technologies aimed at successfully distinguishing life-threatening sounds, such as honking horns or warning sounds, from background noise. TensorFlow Lite was employed as an environment for developing the latest deep learning models capable of recognizing and classifying sounds within minutes. The technology incorporates a compact wearable hearing aid and a linked wristwatch. The former is responsible for detecting surrounding sounds and processing them according to a complex sound classification model that estimates the importance of detected sounds. Vibration alerts are transmitted to the wristwatch, offering quick detection of essential sounds. The proposed architecture is designed to incorporate crucial processes, such as sound pre-processing, feature extraction, and sound classification, aiming to enhance recognition quality while minimizing the occurrence of false positives. In addition, Time Difference of Arrival algorithms are utilized to determine the direction of sounds. This enables the wearer of the device to react quickly to the environmental cues, improving safety and situation awareness, leading to an increased level of independence during various activities. Future advancements of such devices for the hearing impaired community can be promoted through the results obtained, highlighting their superior performance when it comes to the classification and perception of sounds.

Index Terms—Hearing impairment, Sound Classification, TensorFlow lite, AI, Wearable technology, TDOA algorithm

I. INTRODUCTION

Impairments of hearing represent one of the most common public health problems that significantly impact the quality of life and independent functioning of millions of people all over the world. They usually interfere with distinguishing sounds that could be used as a warning about various potentially dangerous situations, such as alarms, sirens, and vehicle horn. Such individuals will not be capable of noticing these sounds, which may put them in potentially lethal danger and make interaction with the environment problematic [3]. Although some significant progress has been achieved in the development of hearing aids, modern devices still cannot provide users with sufficient assistance since they amplify sounds but cannot distinguish important sounds from unnecessary noises [4]. Thus, their inability to filter sounds may be a reason for cognitive overload and missing some significant alerts [5]. Therefore, a smart hearing device capable of classifying and prioritizing sounds should be developed to provide safe navigation in a particular environment [6].

The development of artificial intelligence (AI) creates favorable conditions for improving identification and classification of sounds to solve this problem. Sound identification analysis of ambient noises becomes possible due to advanced classification

The design of this gadget will primarily be aimed at differentiating between critical sounds such as alarm bells and honking vehicles from non-critical background sounds in order to send timely alerts to users via the attached watch. Through its highly advanced audio perception capabilities, it is hoped that users will be able to respond promptly in times of emergencies. In addition, by integrating TDOA algorithms, the performance of the device in terms of determining the direction of sound will be considerably improved. Users will be able to get better awareness of their surroundings in terms of knowing where a particular critical sound originates from and how they should act.

This Deaf Assistance Device equipped with advanced AI technology represents a major milestone in the realm of assistive technology by considering the special challenges encountered by individuals who suffer from hearing impairment. By combining machine learning models with wearable technology, this product not only ensures autonomy and empowerment of users but also facilitates safe navigation of their surroundings. This paper aims to illustrate how the proposed approach can be used to enhance sound recognition, situational awareness and thus, the general quality of life of people suffering from hearing impairment. As the field of assistive technology keeps on evolving, there arises a need for innovative solutions to cater to the special needs of people suffering from hearing loss using modern technologies. Thus, this proposed device seeks to fulfill this void by providing a comprehensive package for enhanced sound detection and direction recognition.

The personalization of sound signals according to the tastes of the user is another feature which ensures that the device will always be convenient and adaptable to different conditions. The adaptability offered will allow users to move around freely and confidently, regardless of whether they are at home, at work, or in public areas [7]. The outcomes generated from this study will contribute further to the existing literature in the area of auditory assistive technologies, paving the way for future advancements which could have an impact on individuals with hearing loss [8].

Types of hearing impairments can be divided into two categories:

- a) Permanent hearing impairment
- b) Temporary hearing impairment

Types of primary hearing impairment are further categorized into:

- a1) Conductive hearing impairment
- b1) Sensorineural hearing impairment

Conductive hearing loss arises due to the failure of sound waves to be transmitted into the inner ear, and this condition is usually associated with the outer ear or the middle ear. Some of the reasons for conductive hearing loss include ear infections, fluid accumulation, and structural abnormalities of

the ear. On the other hand, sensorineural hearing loss occurs due to damages in the inner ear or the auditory pathways that affect sound processing, mostly because of issues such as aging, excessive exposure to noise, or certain genetically acquired conditions. Understanding the types of hearing loss is important to develop appropriate measures to address the problem.

This tool is applied particularly in the processes involving image processing, such as MRI scanning, to identify and quantify the high-density areas accurately. Background noises are quite prevalent in MRI scans, and they may hide information in the process. As such, in detecting tasks where a clearer image needs to be achieved, the removal of background noises becomes inevitable. There are several ways through which the quality of an image may be improved, and they may even be illustrated in the form of flowcharts. Another way through which one can validate the results is by using the watershed transform, where one may identify the different parts of an image.

The sound classification system in the design will be able to precisely classify and differentiate important environmental sounds like alarms, sirens, and car horns from any background sounds that may not be necessary. This will play a crucial role in the lives of people who cannot speak or hear because their safety and awareness depend on them. An advanced system is used to eliminate any unnecessary sounds in the environmental sounds picked up by the device, thus providing accurate audio information to the user.

Such processes make it possible for the proper categorization and recognition of vital sounds. In sound classification, one is able to categorize these vital notifications accurately using advanced methods of analyzing several properties of sound. These processes start with the very first process of audio data processing that seeks to reduce the amount of noise.

Numerous categorization techniques are available for effective sound recognition, including but not limited to:

1. Machine Learning Algorithms
2. Deep Learning Models
3. Signal Processing Techniques
4. Feature Extraction Methods

These methods allow for the precise identification and differentiation of critical environmental sounds. The sound classification model enables the precise identification of critical notifications, including vehicular honking and alarms, by employing sophisticated algorithms that analyze audio features. Beginning with the preprocessing of audio data to suppress noise and enhance intelligibility, each method serves a unique purpose in the enhancement of sound recognition.

II. RELATEDWORK

[1] Veena, S., & Aravindhar, D. J. (2022). In the study conducted by the authors, they proposed the Sound Classification System for Hearing Impaired People (SCSHIP). The article highlights the significance of sound in everyday activities and the challenge faced in detecting useful sounds in noisy environments. Through the integration of IoT and machine learning, SCSHIP aims to help hearing-impaired individuals by enabling sound

detection and classification in real-time. Interpretation of sounds is performed through the use of feature extraction techniques, after which users receive notifications to ensure they stay informed about their environment.

[2] Green, M., & Murphy, D. (2020) presented an approach to assessing soundscapes through a mobile device by machine learning. The study reveals a mobile application that employs the Sennheiser AMBEO Smart Headset to test sound environments in the local surroundings through machine learning and augmented reality. The application assesses sound content in terms of human sounds, natural sounds, and mechanical sounds, and it also allows users to insert virtual sound objects to assess changes in sound levels. For instance, tests conducted in various cities have indicated that the application appropriately assessed natural and mechanical sounds, while the assessment of human sounds was less accurate.

[3] Jiménez-Arberas, E., & Díez, E. (2021). Investigate the psychological effect of assistive devices and technology in Deaf and hard-of-hearing individuals. This study investigates the role played by the devices in facilitating communication, social integration, and quality of life among users. It evaluates both the benefits such as increased independence and knowledge access, and the challenges like stigmatization and technology constraints. The results highlight the need for further advancements in assistive technologies to encourage diversity and empowerment in society.

Moreover, the article talks about the two sides of progress in terms of assistive technology, since although it increases independence and access to various forms of information, it poses challenges such as possible stigma and requirement for user training. Based on the research results, it is necessary to encourage ongoing development and design of new assistive devices which can result in increased empowerment and participation in society among the hearing impaired. This paper addresses the effect of assistive technologies on deaf individuals.

In addition, the researchers consider the wide variety of assistive technologies, including hearing aids, cochlear implants, and smart phone apps, all designed specifically for the individual's personal requirements. The results reveal that, although the use of assistive technology enhances independence and provides access to various kinds of information, there is also an array of new challenges that arise, such as social stigma and user training.

This paper emphasizes the significance of user-based design, emphasizing that including users in the design process produces more successful and fulfilling designs. The researchers urge the ongoing development in this area so that the needs of the deaf and hearing impaired community are addressed through technology, which would allow them to feel empowered and integrated into society.

[4] A new solution for addressing the major barriers in communicating for the deaf community comes through the Deaf Assistance Digital System (DADS). The aim of DADS is to enhance the safety and overall quality of life of the users by converting vital alert sounds and ambiguous utterances into understandable messages. In order to make sure that the user remains connected with the environment and facilitates communication, the advanced neural network and speech recognition systems have been incorporated into the system. This technique is an important inclusion in the field of assistive technologies because, apart from promoting inclusiveness

among hearing-impaired individuals, it also addresses some critical real-world challenges.

- [5] Hassan, F., Mehmood, M. H., Younis, B., Mehmood, N.,
[6] Imran, T., & Zafar, U. (2022).

The proposed research addresses the rising demands for efficient fall detection mechanisms with an increase in the number of elderly people and hazards associated with unintentional falls. The proposed method overcomes the drawbacks of the existing solutions like expensive and complicated wearable sensors along with the privacy concerns related to the installation of cameras. In this paper, by utilizing decision tree classification with features like mel cepstral coefficients and gammatone cepstral coefficients, the authors have managed to obtain a 91.39% accuracy rate with maximum precision and recall values. It becomes clear that the proposed methodology is more reliable than the competing solutions, which makes it suitable for implementation in health care institutions like nursing homes and hospitals.

[7]Kates, J. M. (1998). The current chapter is concerned with the application of digital signal processing within hearing aids with a particular focus on improving speech recognition in patients with hearing disabilities and considering the impact on ambient and musical sounds. There are sections in the chapter which discuss the categories of hearing losses, auditory physiology, and the challenges faced by existing hearing aid systems. In order to improve hearing aids in noisy surroundings, various methods can be applied such as linear amplification, dynamic range compression, and noise reduction.

[8] Demir.F., Abdullah, D. A., & Sengur, A. (2020). In the study, the objective of the paper is to present a new deep Convolutional Neural Network (CNN) architecture for sound event classification. It is indicated that feature extraction is an essential step for sound event classification. Fully connected layers have been used in the suggested CNN network for extracting deep features while using spectrogram image for training the model. Combination of the output obtained from each level creates the feature vector. The performance test was conducted on the DCASE-2017 ASC and UrbanSound8K datasets. The results show that the model successfully classified 96.23% of sounds and 86.70% of sounds.

III PROPOSED METHODOLOGY

Below, you'll find an outline of our algorithm's several steps:

A. Acquiring Sound Input

The suggested solution depends on being able to effectively record sounds from the environment. Even in noisy cities, high-fidelity mics can pick up a wide range of sounds, from car horns to sirens and alarms. Making sure that sound is captured from multiple directions is the biggest challenge, especially in places that are always changing, like streets or public areas.

Not only does this method cover a lot of sound, it also blocks out noise at the record point, so background sounds that aren't important don't get in the way.

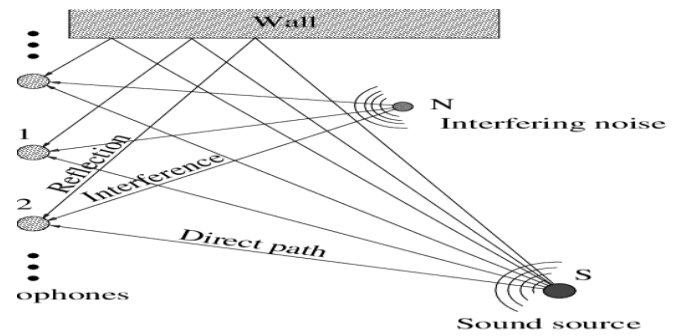


Fig1: Getting sound through Microphone Array

B. Pre-processing

The pre-processing phase is essential in the proposed AI-powered Deaf Assistance Device, as it refines the sound input prior to further classification. It makes use of advanced DSP algorithms that help filter out unnecessary sounds and unwanted noise. It greatly enhances the quality of collected sound signals by employing noise reduction technologies, such as Wiener filters and spectral subtraction. The reason for doing so is to reduce constant background noises, like wind or engine hum, while at the same time retaining essential environmental sounds, like sirens or alarms. In addition to noise cancellation, normalization and equalization techniques are applied to enhance the sound data. Normalization involves boosting the volume of the audio to ensure that even low-level noises are amplified without distorting them, thus facilitating the recognition of significant auditory signals by the subsequent classifier. Conversely, equalization involves balancing the sound frequency in an attempt to counteract the unpredictability of environmental noise through amplifying the frequency bands associated with vital sounds like human voice and sirens.



Fig 2 Pre-processing Flow for Sound Data

In this way, pre-processing transforms the original and noisy sounds to provide a more clear and understandable version that can then be processed more effectively with sound classification methods.

C. Sound Classification:

TensorFlow Lite software is utilized to assist the device to learn about and classify sound signals according to their importance, such as alarms, screams, verbal threats, etc. This learning is made possible by using many datasets of training for detecting essential environmental sounds. Aside from the constantly improving algorithm due to training, it is easy for the algorithm to adapt to new sounds or any change in the background noise. It filters unnecessary noises and prioritizes essential sounds.

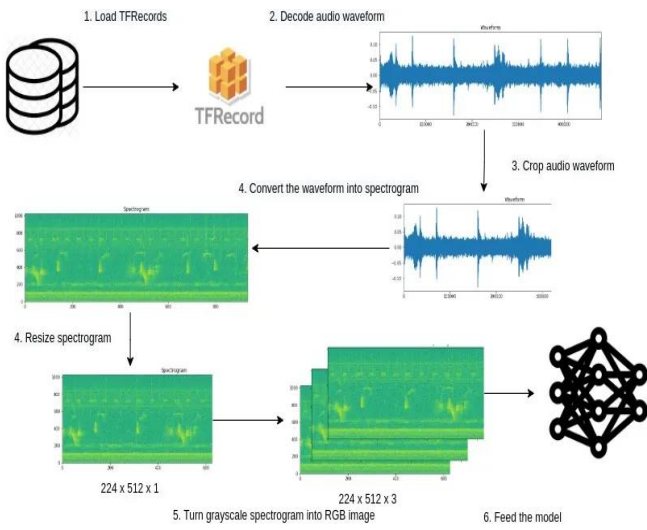


Fig 3 .Classifiaction flow of sound using Tensorflow

D. Direction Detection

Using TDOA methods and a microphone array, the device is capable of pinpointing the source of sounds. Spatial awareness is key for the user as it enables quick and effective reaction to sounds based on their direction.

Direction detection is essential for enhancing situational awareness since it enables the system to recognize potential threats like approaching cars.

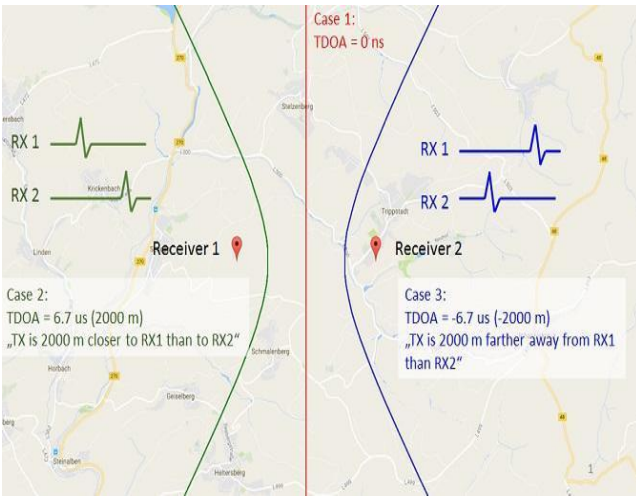


Fig 4:Direction Ditection using TDOA

E. IoT Communication:

IoT-enabled hearing aids are more effective and user-friendly. Real-time information exchange between the hearing aid and wearable devices such as a smartwatch is enabled by this connection.

Since they can receive real-time alerts about significant sounds, the integration ensures that the users will be aware of their surroundings at all times. When there is an alarm, siren, or vehicles approaching from behind, the smartwatch will notify the users with vibrations or visual alerts. Thus, they will not overlook dangerous scenarios in which they may become vulnerable.

Apart from the benefits mentioned above, IoT offers various advantages for hearing aids, such as:

1.Remote Software Updates: Over the air, users receive regular updates of software on their devices. As a result, users do not need to visit technicians to get their device software

updated or to get new features.

2.Adaptability: The system may be updated in a remote manner according to any newly-discovered sound type or categories. This feature ensures that users are able to adjust their experience based on their environment or personal preference. Hence, it increases adaptability of the device.

F. Feedback Mechanism

Haptic Feedback: Here waves of varying magnitudes will be utilized. In case there is a sudden occurrence, which may require immediate attention, such as vehicles approaching from behind or fire alarm, the system will give a warning in the form of powerful wave. Thus, there is no dependence on hearing information alone since the user receives physical feedback.

Visual Feedback: Light flashing in the wearable device serves as a visual feedback to alert the user about important sounds. For instance, through vivid LED indicators, a user is able to receive warnings from different sound categories. This allows quick evaluation of a situation.

This approach proves very helpful especially when aural feedback cannot be heard due to visual distraction.

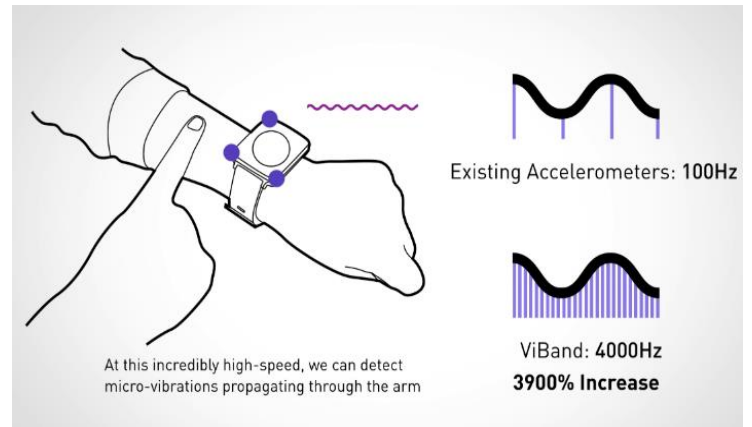


Fig 5:Feedback mechanism to the user

G. User Personalization with Mobile App

A user could employ a simple-to-use mobile application on the phone in order to control and customize his hearing experience. Some of the personalization features to make the experience better include customizing the sound profiles based on location (in-house, in-office, or outside in the street), tweaking vibration/visual feedback intensity, and checking out the history of sounds detected.

Users could also personalize sound classification models through the application, and in the end, the capacity of the device to detect unknown sounds would improve.

Step 1: Specifying sound detection and feedback preferences by users.

Step 2: Monitoring sound detection history.

Step 3: Upgrading sound classification models through cloud or app upgrades.

IV RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

To comprehend the connection between hearing impairments and road safety in detail, one should consider the staggering figures, which prove the high vulnerability of the deaf population to traffic

accidents. Several studies indicate that deaf individuals are prone to accidents compared to those who do not have any auditory impairments. The reason for that is the lack of ability to hear critical sounds such as horn or siren. Moreover, accidents of hearing persons are 30% less likely to occur to deaf persons. It clearly demonstrates the need for assistive devices aimed at increasing deaf individuals' awareness of their environment.

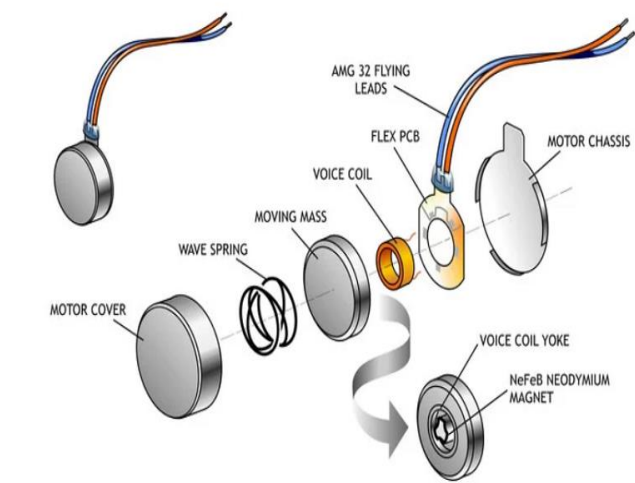


Fig 6:Normal hearing Aid Components

As indicated in a recent study by the National Institute for Health Research, 40% of the 1,200 deaf population involved in the study experienced one or more car accidents during their lifetime. This is because the lack of sensory signals in their surrounding environment can make deaf individuals susceptible to hazards, particularly those in urban environments where there is an abundance of noises of various types.

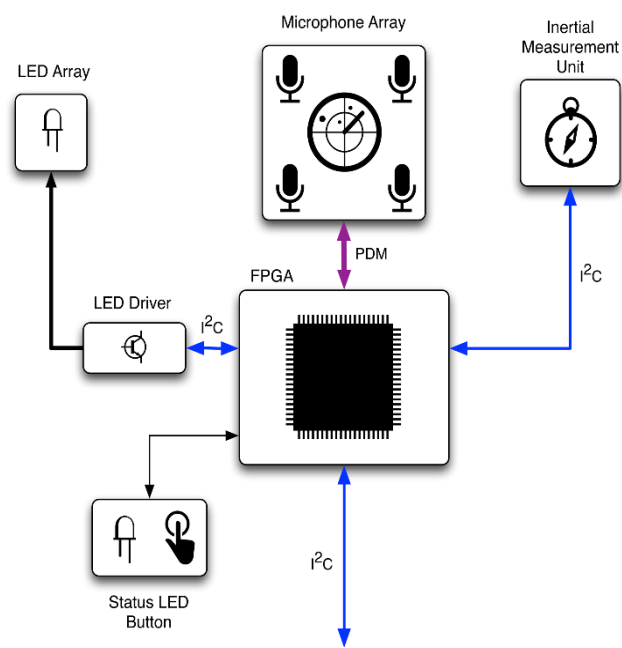


Fig 7:Working of Microphone Array

To conclude, from the above information, the safety statistics related to deaf people reveal the critical need for technological innovations to increase their auditory awareness. The suggested innovation aims at ensuring the safety and wellbeing of deaf individuals through

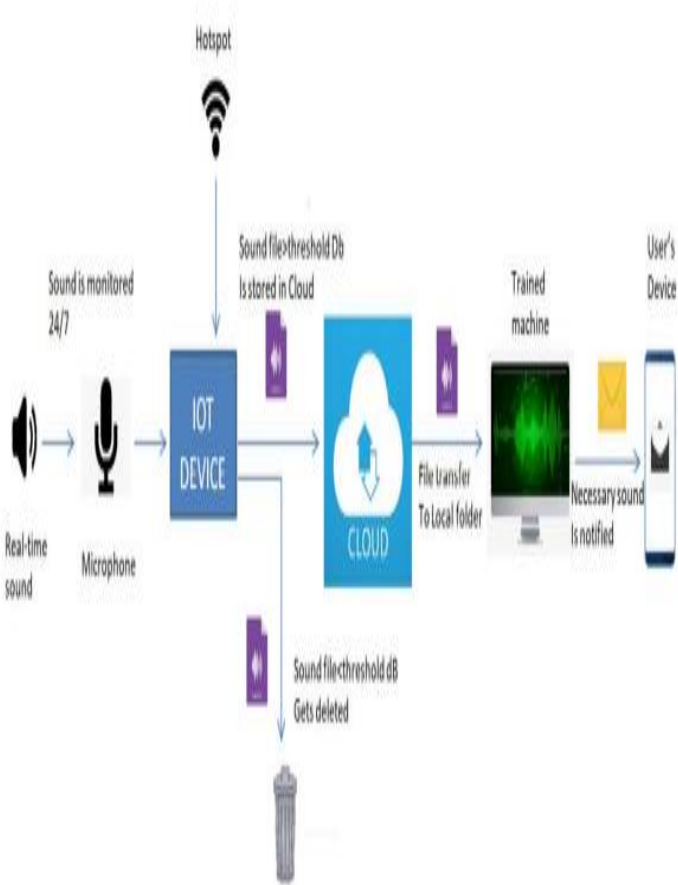
technological advancements. It will help them feel safe while moving around.

Classes	Accuracy %	Precision%	Recall%	F1-Score%
Car Honks	94.12	97	96.2	98.11
Sirens	92.78	98.33	93.89	98
Background chatter	92.09	99	91.10	94.58
Wind	100	100	100	100

Table1:ML model accuracy

Advanced machine learning models are employed in the development of the device to categorize environmental sounds into critical alarms and unwanted noise. It will be more comfortable for deaf and hearing-impaired individuals as such technology ensures the safety of users. With the help of real-time processing of audio and feedback tailored according to the wishes of users via a smartwatch, the system will be capable of adapting to various environments and settings that will guarantee the awareness of the individual about everything happening in the environment.

Fig 8:Workflow of the model



V .CONCLUSION

To conclude, the development of the AI-Powered Deaf Assistance Device represents a considerable leap forward in developing new ways of improving the lives of hearing-impaired individuals. The goal of this invention consists in helping its users identify critical environmental sounds, like alarms and even conversations, using machine learning algorithms and IoT capabilities. Furthermore, the benefits of this technology do not merely consist in helping individuals hear their surroundings better; instead, it helps promote inclusiveness and helps deaf individuals participate in social activities actively. As the research proves, the implementation of accurate sound recognition can significantly benefit the situational awareness of deaf individuals and help address critical communication problems faced by them. Moreover, real-time feedback features, including alerts transmitted through a smart watch, help ensure that the individual will know about any important sounds in their environment. According to recent studies, the implementation of advanced signal processing techniques and deep learning methods results in considerable improvements in identifying relevant sounds and eliminating any unnecessary background noises from the analysis. Overall, the invention represents an effective means of resolving accessibility problems experienced by individuals with hearing disabilities and an opportunity to continue discussing technological advances in this area.

VI FUTUREWORK

Future endeavors regarding the AI-Powered Deaf Assistance Device will concentrate on refining the sound classification algorithms to augment precision and responsiveness. This entails the exploration of sophisticated machine learning methodologies, including transfer learning and ensemble approaches, to utilize pre-trained models on extensive datasets. Furthermore, incorporating user input mechanisms would facilitate the ongoing enhancement of the sound classification system, rendering it more responsive to specific user contexts and preferences. Studies indicate that user-centered designs result in more efficient assistive devices. Moreover, augmenting the dataset to encompass a broader range of environmental sounds will strengthen the system's robustness, guaranteeing its capacity to reliably recognize sounds in many circumstances and locales. In addition, the device's future iterations will investigate the integration of augmented reality (AR) to offer visual cues in addition to auditory notifications. The device can provide a comprehensive comprehension of the user's environment by overlaying relevant information in the user's field of view through a mobile app or smart glasses. In addition, the device will be tailored to the unique requirements of users with differing degrees of hearing impairment through collaboration with audiologists and hearing specialists. Overall, the AI-Powered Deaf Assistance Device's continuous development and improvement are designed to establish a solution that is truly inclusive and enables individuals with hearing disabilities to independently and effectively navigate their surroundings

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